

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

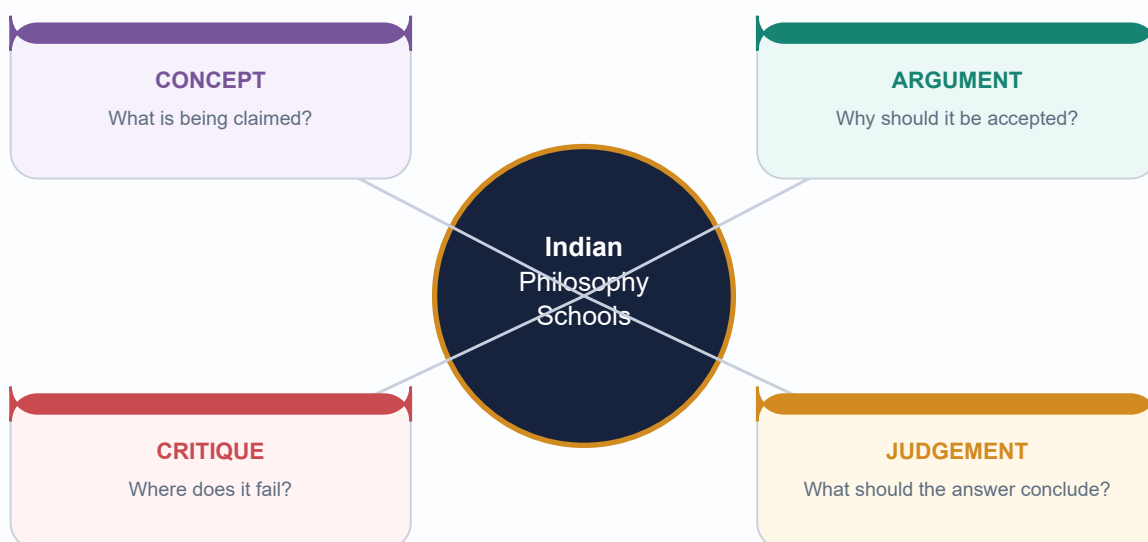
Indian Philosophy: Schools of Buddhism

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper I | Indian Philosophy

Visual learning edition: central maps, argument flows, comparisons and PYQ frameworks

Syllabus: Pratityasamutpada; Ksanikavada; Nairatmyavada.

Direct-source base: Chatterjee and Datta, Bauddha Philosophy chapter (local PDF pp. 101-134); C. D. Sharma, Early Buddhism, Sunyavada, and Vijnanavada chapters (printed pp. 57-136). Cross-checked with Paper I PYQs, 2022-2025.



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Central Mind Map: Conditioned Arising without Substance

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The syllabus doctrines form one argument. Dependent origination rejects self-sufficient being; momentariness explains conditioned existence as a causal series; no-self denies an enduring owner behind the aggregates.

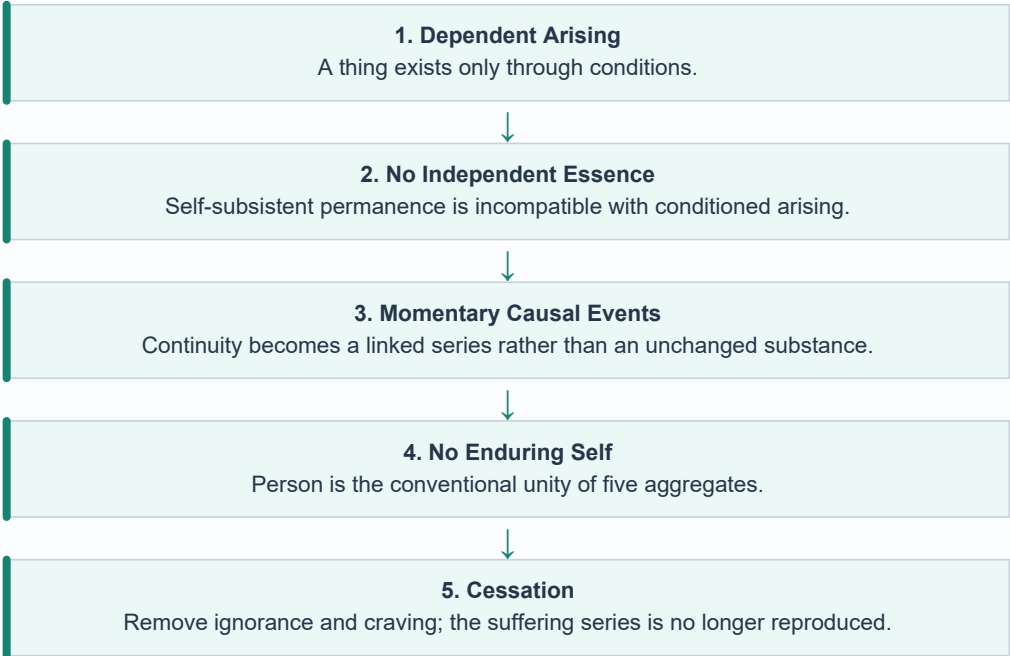
Early Buddhist teachings and later schools differ in ontology, but all use conditionality to reject permanent independent substance. The exact original school formulations are historically layered, so the notes distinguish common doctrine from later Madhyamika and Yogacara development.

BUDDHIST DOCTRINE MAP

WHATEVER ARISES, ARISES DEPENDENTLY

Pratityasamutpada Conditioned co-arising; middle path between eternalism and annihilationism.	Twelve Links Ignorance and craving sustain the cycle of suffering.
Ksanikavada The real is a causally effective moment in a stream.	Nairatmyavada No permanent self beyond five conditioned aggregates.
Nirvana Cessation of the causal conditions of suffering.	Schools Realist, representationist, consciousness-only, and emptiness interpretations.

CORE ARGUMENT FLOW



MEMORY HOOK

DEPENDENT -> MOMENTARY -> NO-SELF -> CESSATION. The same causal logic links all four.

CONCEPT LINKS

Buddhist Concept	Linked Doctrine	Exam Value
Dependent origination	Madhyamika emptiness	What is dependent lacks independent own-being.
Momentary stream	Jaina permanence-in-change	Series continuity versus enduring substance.
No-self	Nyaya and Vedanta self	Bundle/stream versus substantial or absolute self.
Causal efficacy	Karma and rebirth	Continuity without numerical identity.

MAINS ANGLE

Buddhism replaces substance-continuity with conditioned causal continuity.

STUDY LINK

Official syllabus item 14; present the three doctrines as a chain, not isolated definitions.

HIGH

Pratityasamutpada and the Twelve-Link Causal Flow

Paper I
Philosophy

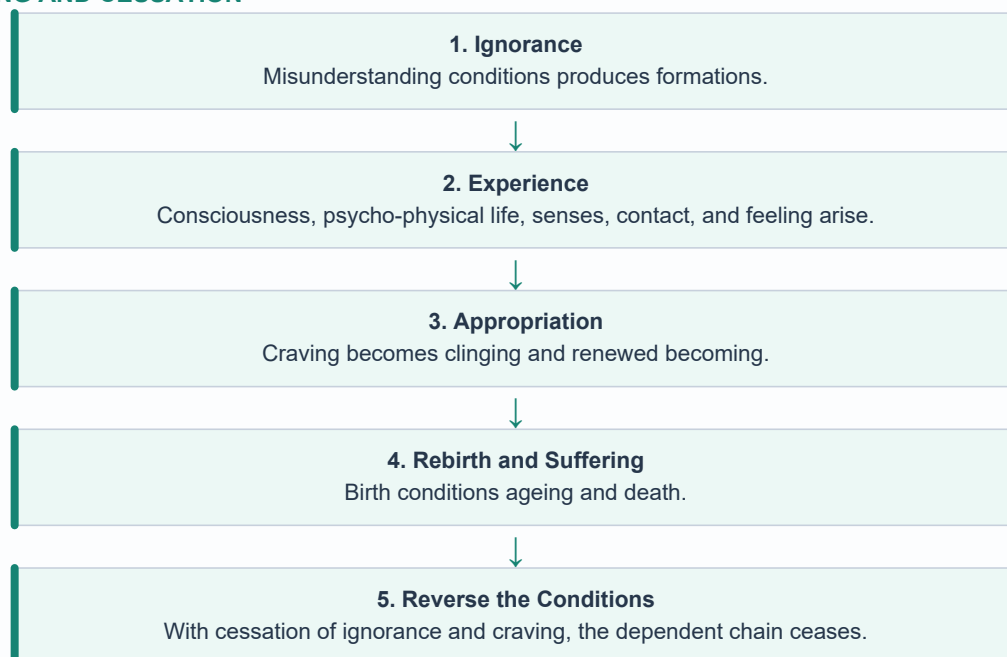
INTRO & ORIGIN

Pratityasamutpada states that events arise when their conditions are present and cease when those conditions cease. It is explanatory and soteriological: the same chain that produces suffering identifies where it can be stopped.

KEY DATA

Link	Function	Analytical Group
Avidya	Ignorance of the nature of reality.	Past cause
Samskara	Volitional formations shaped by ignorance.	Past cause
Vijnana	Conditioned consciousness.	Present result
Nama-rupa	Mental and bodily organization.	Present result
Sadayatana	Six sense bases.	Present result
Sparsa	Contact of sense, object, and consciousness.	Present result
Vedana	Feeling generated by contact.	Present result
Trsna	Craving for pleasant continuation and escape from pain.	Present cause
Upadana	Clinging or appropriation.	Present cause
Bhava	Becoming that prepares further existence.	Present cause
Jati	Birth.	Future result
Jara-marana	Ageing, death, and associated suffering.	Future result

SUFFERING AND CESSATION



STATIC THEORY

- **Middle path:** dependent origination avoids a permanent eternal substance and the claim that events occur without causes.
- **No first cause required:** explanation proceeds through conditioned relations rather than a creator or unconditioned worldly substance.
- **Soteriological priority:** the doctrine maps the production and cessation of suffering rather than offering speculative cosmology.
- **Emptiness link:** later Madhyamika argues that dependence entails absence of svabhava or self-nature.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Avidya is the root condition; craving and clinging are practical points of intervention.
2. The links can be grouped across past causes, present results and causes, and future results.
3. Nirvana is approached through cessation of conditions, not destruction of a permanent self.

MAINS ANGLE

The theory is causal without being substantialist: relations explain arising, and transformed conditions explain cessation.

STUDY LINK

Use the chain in 2023 dependent-origination and 2025 nirvana questions.

HIGH

Ksanikavada and Nairatmyavada

Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Momentariness denies enduring entities; no-self denies an enduring person. Buddhism explains apparent persistence through santana, a causally connected stream.

KEY DATA

Doctrine / Term	Meaning	Standard Illustration
Ksanikavada	Whatever is real exists as a momentary causal event.	Flame or river appears continuous while changing.
Arthakriyakritva	Reality is identified with causal efficacy.	A real moment produces its effect.
Santana	Causal continuum of distinct moments.	One flame lights another.
Five skandhas	Form, feeling, perception, dispositions, consciousness.	Person is their conventional aggregate.
Nairatmyavada	No permanent self exists beyond conditioned aggregates.	Chariot has no entity beyond assembled parts.
Conventional person	Practical designation for the stream.	Karma language works without a substance-self.

ARGUMENT FROM CAUSAL EFFICACY TO MOMENTARINESS**STATIC THEORY**

- **Memory objection:** recognition seems to require the same knower across time.
- **Buddhist reply:** a later cognition is causally conditioned by earlier experience; numerical identity is unnecessary.
- **Moral responsibility objection:** if the doer perishes, why should another moment receive the fruit?
- **Reply:** later moments are neither strictly identical nor unrelated; they belong to the same causal series.
- **Liberation issue:** nirvana concerns cessation of the defiled series, not the release of an eternal soul.

MEMORY HOOK

NO SUBSTANCE, NOT NO CONTINUITY: continuity belongs to causal relation, not an unchanging carrier.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Nairatmyavada rejects a permanent atman, not ordinary conventional agency.
2. The five aggregates are all conditioned and impermanent.
3. Karma and rebirth are explained through causal transmission in the stream.

MAINS ANGLE

The stream theory preserves explanatory continuity, but critics question whether causal relatedness alone is enough for memory and responsibility.

STUDY LINK

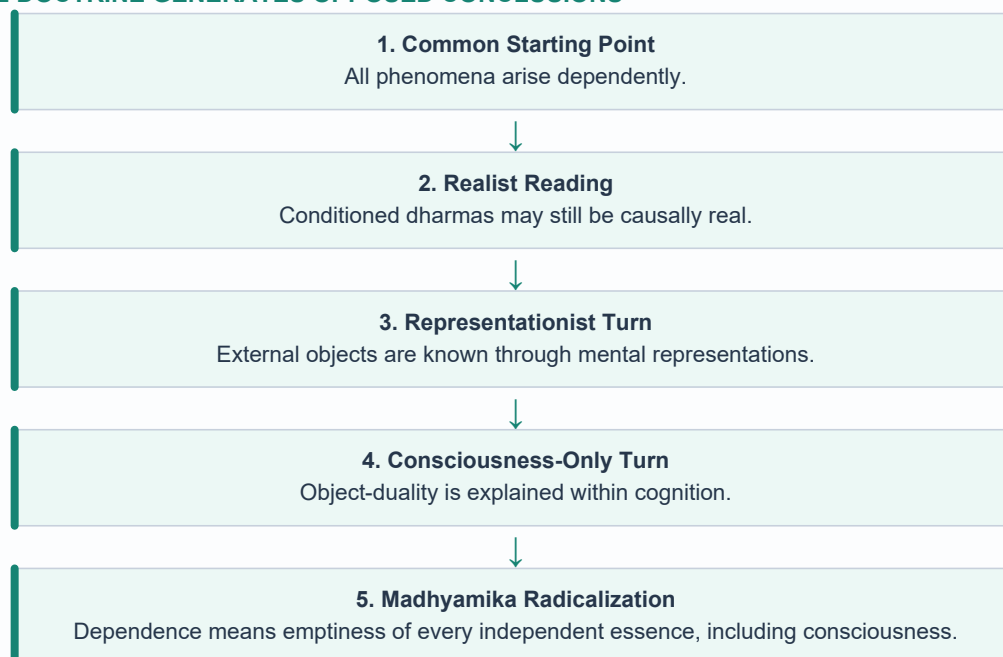
Pair ksanikavada with karma in 2022 and with nirvana in 2025.

HIGH**Four Schools and Strongest Criticism-Defence**Paper I
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The four-school classification shows different answers to what, if anything, is real when permanent substances are rejected.

KEY DATA

School	External Object	Core Position
Vaibhasika	Real and directly perceived.	Direct realism about external dharmas.
Sautrantika	Real but inferred from representations.	Representative realism.
Yogacara / Vijñānavāda	External object denied.	Cognition-only; store-consciousness explains continuity.
Madhyamika / Sunyavada	Neither independently real nor a simple nothing.	All dharmas are empty of self-nature; two truths.

HOW ONE DOCTRINE GENERATES OPPOSED CONCLUSIONS

STATIC THEORY

- **Strongest criticism:** without an enduring subject, memory, recognition, moral desert, and liberation appear unintelligible.
- **Strongest defence:** identity is not required for continuity; causal inheritance explains how later moments depend on earlier ones.
- **Against nihilism:** sunyata means emptiness of independent self-nature, not that nothing functions conventionally.
- **Internal caution:** Yogacara's alaya-vijnana must not be converted into a hidden permanent self.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Vaibhasika and Sautrantika are realist in different epistemic senses.
2. Yogacara denies external objects but retains structured consciousness.
3. Madhyamika applies emptiness universally and distinguishes conventional from ultimate truth.

COMPARISON TABLE

Issue	Buddhist Answer	Opponent
Self	Aggregate or stream	Nyaya: enduring individual substance
Change	Momentary causal events	Jainism: substance with changing modes
Ultimate reality	No independent svabhava	Advaita: Brahman
Causation	Dependent origination	Samkhya: effect pre-exists in material cause

MAINS ANGLE

Buddhist anti-substantialism is strongest as a theory of conditioned process; its hardest burden is personal continuity.

STUDY LINK

Use the realism-to-emptiness gradient for the 2024 schools question.

HIGH

PYQ Routes and 10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

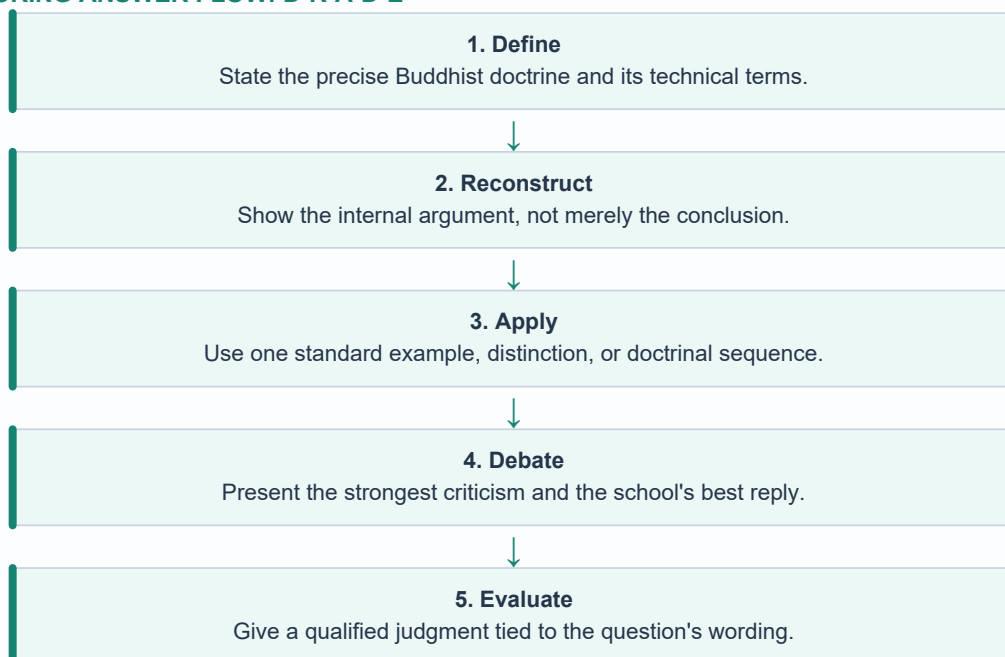
Paper I
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

UPSC repeatedly tests a narrow doctrine through comparison, internal tension, criticism, or an applied example. The answer should reconstruct the school's reasoning before evaluating it.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 20	Compatibility of momentariness and karma; replies to objections.	Santana, causal efficacy, responsibility.
2022 / 15	Triratna and consistency with no-self.	Path without an eternal agent.
2023 / 20	Dependent origination as account of suffering and cessation.	Twelve links and reverse cessation.
2024 / 15	How two schools derive 'everything is real' and 'everything is void' from dependent origination.	Realist dharmas versus emptiness of svabhava.
2025 / 15	Nirvana with momentariness and no-self.	Cessation of causal defilements without soul-substance.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER FLOW: D-R-A-D-E**STATIC THEORY**

- **10 marks:** define one doctrine, give its argument or twelve-link position, state one objection and reply.
- **15 marks:** connect dependent origination, momentariness, and no-self; apply stream/chariot examples; assess continuity.
- **20 marks:** reconstruct the causal theory, explain karma or nirvana, distinguish schools, present Nyaya/Jaina criticism, and evaluate anti-substantial continuity.
- **Applied drill:** Explain personal continuity from childhood to adulthood without an unchanging self, using causal-series logic.
- **Applied drill:** Remove craving from one link in the twelvefold chain and show the soteriological consequence without treating nirvana as a substance.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Write the Sanskrit technical term once, then explain it in plain language.
2. Separate exposition, criticism, defence, and final assessment.
3. Use comparison only where it clarifies the precise issue asked.
4. For statement questions, interpret the statement before presenting doctrine.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** No-self means nothing exists.
CORRECT: It denies a permanent self, not conventional persons or causal events. Avoid nihilism.
- WRONG:** Sunyata is absolute non-being.
CORRECT: It is emptiness of independent own-being. Essential Madhyamika correction.
- WRONG:** Momentariness destroys all continuity.
CORRECT: Buddhism substitutes causal continuity for substance identity. Answer karma objections.
- WRONG:** Alaya-vijnana is an eternal soul.
CORRECT: It is a conditioned explanatory continuum in Yogacara. Preserve no-self.

UPSC TRAPS AND CORRECTIONS

Common Trap	Correction	Answer Use
No-self means nothing exists.	It denies a permanent self, not conventional persons or causal events.	Avoid nihilism.
Sunyata is absolute non-being.	It is emptiness of independent own-being.	Essential Madhyamika correction.
Momentariness destroys all continuity.	Buddhism substitutes causal continuity for substance identity.	Answer karma objections.
Alaya-vijnana is an eternal soul.	It is a conditioned explanatory continuum in Yogacara.	Preserve no-self.

MAINS ANGLE

Buddhism gives a rigorous process ontology and therapeutic account of suffering; its success depends on whether causal continuity can bear the work usually assigned to substance and self.

STUDY LINK

Revise the master map, doctrine table, criticism-defence grid, and PYQ routes together.